

GOA: SELF-RELIANCE FOR SUCCESS

Prime Minister Narendra Modi lauds Chief Minister Dr Pramod Sawant on Goa's achievements as India's smallest state celebrates the 60th anniversary of its liberation.

There was much fanfare, thousands of people and a fantastic display of Goa's pride during its recent Liberation Day celebrations. India's smallest state was one of the last territories to be freed from colonial rule but has progressed quickly since that momentous day in 1961.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Goa marked the culmination of a year of celebrating the state's 60th anniversary of its liberation from Portuguese rule. He lauded the state government for its developmental achievements, noting Goa's success in various governance indices.

"The new identity of the state is that of being foremost in every task of governance. In other places where work starts, Goa has already completed it," he said during his speech at the Dr Shyama Prasad Mukherjee Stadium just outside the capital Panjim on December 19.

His brief visit included the felicitation of Goa's freedom fighters, the inauguration of various development projects, awards to panchayats and municipalities, tributes to the state's fallen heroes and attending a sail parade and fly past by armed forces stationed here.

Modi expressed particular admiration for the achievements of the state government led by Dr Pramod Sawant. Patting the chief minister on his back, Modi recognised his steps to introduce coding and robotics in schools under the Diamond Jubilee Gift Scheme.

He said, "If Goa has an endless sea, the youth have dreams just as expansive. To fulfill these dreams we need a vision to match. I can say that Sawant is working with a vision like this. Where will Goa reach by the time it celebrates 75 years of liberation? Make new resolutions. Goa needs continuity. The pace of development should stay the same in the future. We should not stop or decrease speed."

Crediting Goa's success to all the governments that have worked for its development since its liberation in 1961, Dr Pramod Sawant pointed out that they have all done their best "to ensure the development path and see Goa where it is today". He added, "My government takes its decisions in the interest of the state and its people, irrespective of caste and religion. My government believes in sabka saath, sabka vikas."

He urged the people of this beautiful state to work unitedly towards its progress through the central and state Atmanirbhar Bharat and Swayampurna Goa initiatives, while keeping it clean, green and a sustainable, peace-loving place to ensure development in all areas.

The Prime Minister later inaugurated a slew of development projects in Goa, worth more than Rs 600 crore. These included a renovated jail museum at Fort Aguada, the prison where many freedom fighters had been incarcerated; a super specialty block at Goa Medical College; a new district hospital in South Goa; an aviation skill development centre at the new Greenfield Airport in Mopa and a gas-insulated substation at Dabolim- Navelim near Margao.

Additionally, he released a special cover and cancellation to mark the commemoration of the Indian armed forces freeing Goa from colonial rule.

He released 'My Stamp' depicting the Hutatma Smarak at Patradevi, saluting the sacrifices of martyrs in the liberation movement, and accepted a Meghdoot postcard showcasing a collage of images of various events from the freedom struggle.

The Prime Minister accompanied the Chief Minister and State Governor P S Sreedhran Pillai to Azad Maidan, where he laid a wreath at the foot of the Martyrs Memorial and spent a few minutes in reverence of all those who laid down their lives for Goa's freedom. Modi said,
" The history of Goa's freedom struggle is not just a symbol of India's resolve, but a living document of India's unity and integrity." Pointing out that despite centuries of upheavals and transfers of power, he stated that "Goa did not forget India nor did India forget Goa", and that Goans kept the flames of freedom burning for the longest time in India's history.

During his visit, the Prime Minister also paid tribute to former Chief Minister late